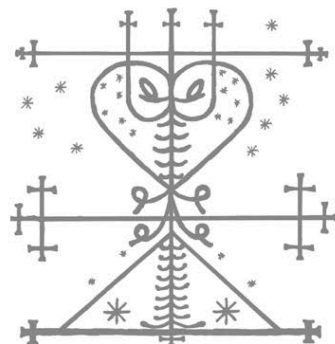


EVERYTHING IS SPIRIT

Voodoo and Hoodoo

Although Voodoo—more accurately called Voudon, which translates as spirit—and Hoodoo are related, their differences are significant. Both are African in origin, carried by slaves across the Atlantic in the 18th century to France's Caribbean colonies and territories along the Mississippi. Both were also altered by influences in their new surroundings, Voudon by Catholicism, and Hoodoo by other faith systems, European as well as Native American. Yet the key fact remains: that Voudon is a religion, while Hoodoo is a form of folk magic.



◀ Veve

A Voudon ritual starts with the drawing of a symbol, known as a veve, on the ground with scattered corn starch. Animal sacrifice follows, both elements critical in summoning a *lwa* (spirit). The origins are lost, but veves are claimed to represent astral forces.

transported to the island, where they were subject to France's Code Noir, which outlawed all religions except Catholicism and insisted that the enslaved should become Catholic.

Origins of Voudon in Haiti

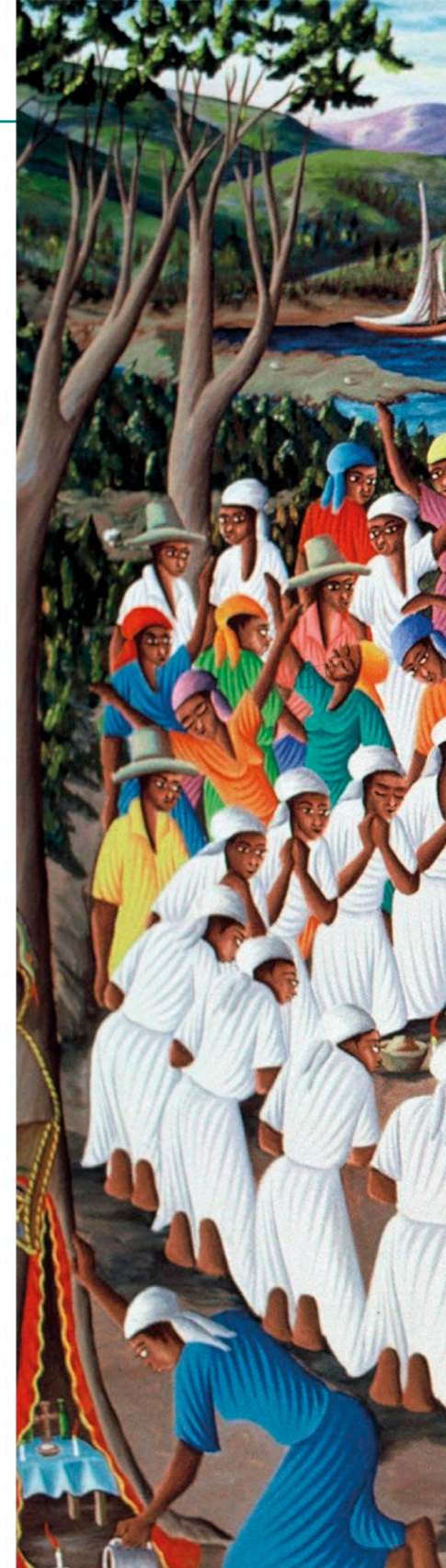
From its roots in the Fon religion of West Africa, Voudon evolved in the Caribbean on the island of Saint Domingue (modern Haiti). This was France's richest colony, exporting coffee and sugar produced by enslaved people. Slavery was the defining feature of Voudon. More than a million West Africans were

Mystical world

The result was a remarkable hybrid—a mingling of beliefs, practices, and world views known as syncretic religion—that fused the original spirit and ancestor worship of the enslaved with Catholicism. Although Voudon followers believe in an overarching god, the creator of all things, called Bondye (a corruption of the French Bon Dieu or Good God), he is too remote to be directly worshipped and there is no single liturgy. Instead, god is worshipped through thousands of spirits known as *lwa* or *loa*, who represent every aspect of the world and of humanity. It is in these spirits that the deeply mystical nature of Voudon truly reveals itself.

Possession and revelation

Voudon followers believe in two worlds: visible and invisible; the domains of the living and the dead. The spirits of the dead are always among the living, but they can only be made manifest



► Voudon doll

As symbols of a bounteous world, Voudon dolls—this one a female figure with an animal head—are central to the exuberant celebration of nature. They proclaim a delight in the real world and fecundity.

“... [sprinkle cow manure scorched] with red pepper and white people's hair ... in my master's bedroom to stop him abusing me.”

NARRATIVE OF THE LIFE AND ADVENTURES OF HENRY BIBB, AN AMERICAN SLAVE, 1849